

The key lies in changing shopping from a hobby into a job. This is critically important, so let me rephrase and repeat. Shopping, from a financial independence standpoint, is not a hobby. It is a job. A responsibility to be taken seriously. Following are some power-shopping strategies to put you in the driver's seat.

1. Shop your service plans and other accounts

Service plans, account packages, and card rates change all the time. Companies are rarely, if ever, going to track you down and let you know that they have a better plan or package for you. Calling a card company to negotiate a lower interest rate (if you carry a balance), asking what new plans are out there to save you money, or evaluating your changing usage of a particular plan to select a new one (cell phones are a good example of when this is necessary) are all ways to carve out extra cash. If you spend an afternoon evaluating and researching new account options, including those you may no longer even need, and find an extra \$50 a month, you are actually finding an extra \$600 annually.

2. Maintain lists for home information management

What items do the kids need for school? What grocery items

(including semiannual bulk purchases) are you running low on or out of? What are the sizes and measurements of each family member? What types of lightbulbs, air filters, etc., do your home systems and vehicles take? This is all critical information to have if you want to shop sales effectively.

3. Know the sale trends

Certain things traditionally go on sale at particular times of the year, such as August for camping equipment and athletic shoes, July for picnic condiments, and January for gift wraps and holiday items. If you know of something you want, can be disciplined enough to save ahead, and are able to wait for the sales, you can save major money.

4. Celebrate clearance sales

No, this does not mean you get to max out your credit card every time there's a seasonal shoe sale. It does mean that there are big savings to be had, particularly on classic items of good quality. This is an excellent strategy to partner up with the second suggestion on the list. Having your home and family needs lists current enables you to pick up those items inexpensively if you run into a slamming sale on the fly.